ASSIGNMENT #1 ELEMENTS & PRINCIPLES OF DESIGN INTERIOR DESIGN

SHAN CÁFE

Robot 3 Studio

Sculpted Spaces for Inspired Living .

PRESENTED BY:

PRIYA

RHONA

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Introduction

SHAN CAFÉ (BAN SHAN CAFÉ)

- Design Studio / Architects: Robot3 Studio — Fei Pan, Zhi-Bang Shao, Xiao-Han Li
- Location: East side of Jing Yuan Arts Center, Beijing, China
- Area: ~600 m²
- Year Completed: 2015
- Concept: A “free café” designed to encourage people to stay, relax, and communicate openly.
- Design Inspiration: “Shan” (mountain), inspired by Su Shi’s poem describing the shifting views of peaks.
- Challenge: Ceiling height of 3.8 m — too tall for one floor, too short for two floors.
- Solution:
  - Dug 1 m down to create a sunken pit
  - Added a mezzanine level
  - Built a log cabin under the stairs
  - Used plant shelves as partitions to define spaces

ELEMENTS OF DESIGN

1. **Vertical lines**
partitions, walls, railings → emphasize height and order.

2. Horizontal lines
mezzanine edges, long shelves → stability, grounding.

Line

ARE THE SIMPLEST DESIGN ELEMENT, USED TO DEFINE FORM AND GUIDE THE VIEWER'S EYE.

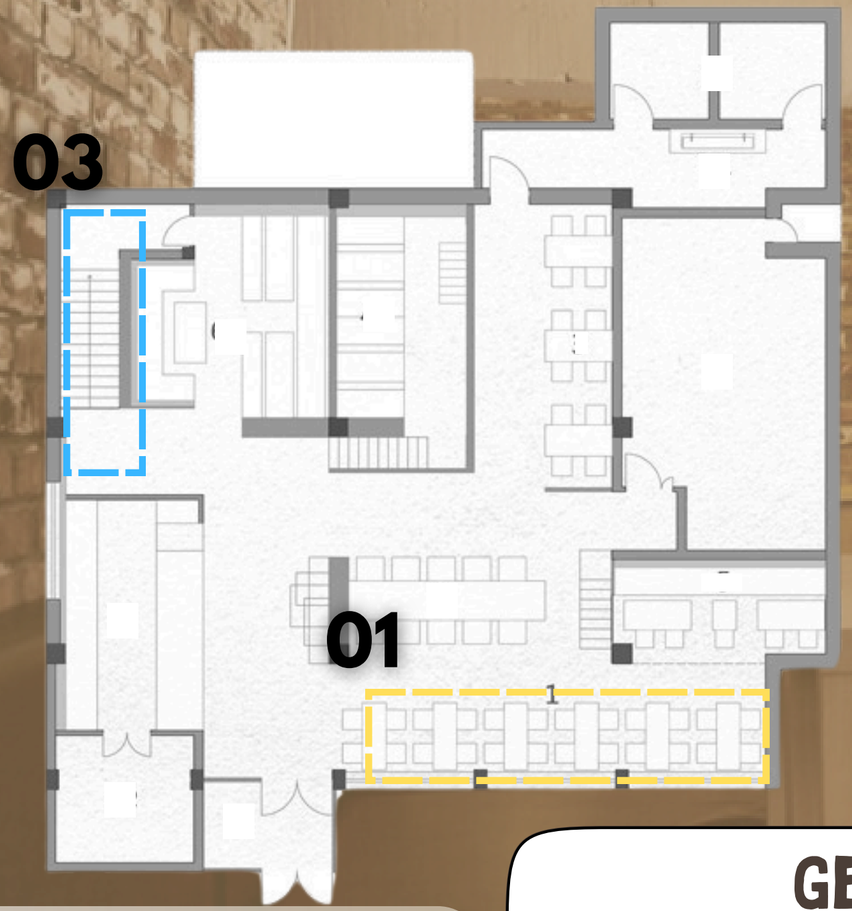
3. Diagonal lines
stairs and ramps → suggest motion and transition.

4. Curved/Organic lines
plant partitions, furniture edges → soften geometry, add natural flow.

Shape & Form

THE DIALOGUE OF FORMS: GEOMETRY MEETS NATURE

2. Planar Forms:The flat surfaces of the long wooden dining table and rectangular planters.



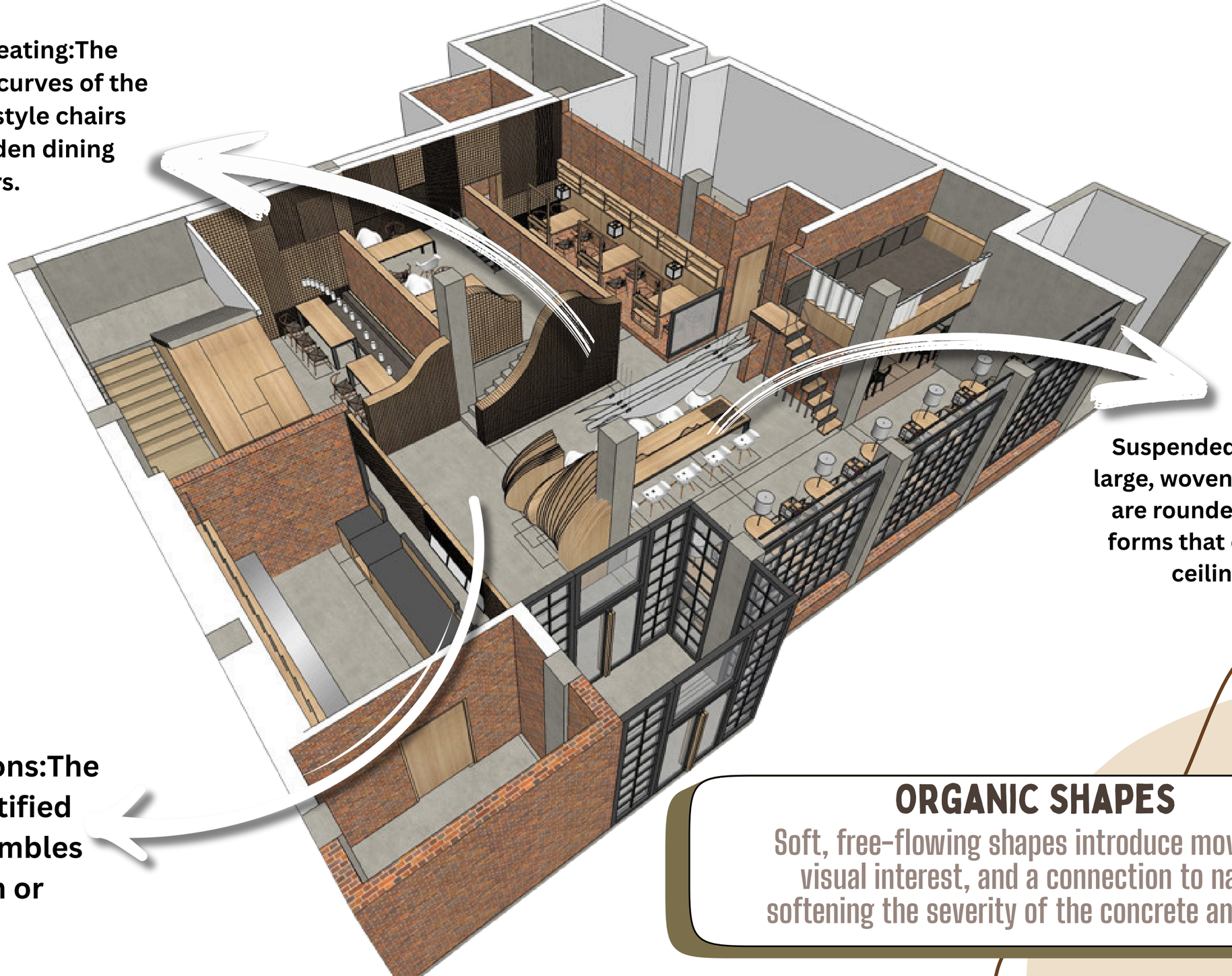
1. Grid Structure: Exposed beams, metal window frames, and strict table layouts.

GEOMETRICAL FORMS

The foundation of the space relies on the predictability and stability of orthogonal lines and hard angles, providing a sense of order and industrial scale.

3. Stepped Forms: The sharp, right-angled treads of the black metal staircase.

Curvilinear Seating:The gentle, molded curves of the white Eames-style chairs and the wooden dining chairs.



Suspended Spheres:The large, woven pendant lights are rounded, volumetric forms that command the ceiling space.

Sculptural Partitions:The undulating, stratified wall feature resembles natural terrain or mountains

ORGANIC SHAPES

Soft, free-flowing shapes introduce movement, visual interest, and a connection to nature, softening the severity of the concrete and metal.

Space

DESIGNED TO BE FUNCTIONAL AND WELCOMING, OFFERING A CLEAN AND COMFORTABLE SETTING SUITED FOR DIFFERENT OCCASIONS.

High vs Low

pit is sunken, mezzanine is raised, creating layered spatial experience.

Open vs Intimate

large floor below feels communal, mezzanine and log cabin feel cozy/private.

NATURAL LIGHT

FILTERED BY PLANT SHELVES (CHANGING WITH TIME OF DAY).

ARTIFICIAL LIGHTING

FROM PENDANT LIGHT WHICH IS ADDING WARMTH IN ENCLOSED AREAS.

WARM AND COZY

THE CONTRAST OF LIGHT & SHADOW WILL HELP IN ENHANCING THE MOOD

Texture

REFERS TO THE SURFACE QUALITY OF A MATERIAL, HOW IT FEELS OR APPEARS TO FEEL.

SOFT & NATURAL

PLANTS (FRESH, LIVING).

SMOOTH

POLISHED WOOD FURNITURE (WARM, TACTILE).

ROUGH

EXPOSED BRICK WALLS (RAW, RUSTIC).

Color

THE LIGHTING DESIGN IN THIS SPACE IS A CRUCIAL ELEMENT THAT CONTRIBUTES SIGNIFICANTLY TO THE OVERALL INDUSTRIAL CHIC AMBIANCE, BALANCING THE RAW MATERIALS WITH A WARM, INVITING GLOW.

Creates warmth, natural atmosphere, and consistency.

COLOR PALATTE

Earth tones: browns, oranges, greens, and neutrals.

How a cohesive strategy of **Warm Neutrals and **Contrasting Cools defines the mood.

01.

Warm Dominance (Brick & Wood)

The primary palette consists of rich, earthy tones: the deep reds and browns of exposed brick and the soft, golden hues of natural wood. This combination is inherently inviting and cozy.

02.

Cool Contrast (Concrete & White)

Grey concrete floors and pillars, along with crisp white seating (Eames chairs), provide a crucial cooling contrast. This prevents the warm tones from becoming overwhelming, adding a modern, industrial edge

03.

Light: The Defining Color Accent

The lighting itself is a color element—it's intensely warm (low Kelvin), washing the entire space in a soft, golden glow. This highly saturated light enhances the natural wood and red bricks dramatically.

Scale

IS THE SIZE OF AN OBJECT IN RELATION TO ITS SURROUNDINGS.

HUMAN SCALE FURNITURE

With people in the image, the most direct sense of scale is provided. You can now easily gauge the height of the table, chairs, and lamps relative to an average person.

GRAND OR MONUMENTAL SCALE

The high ceilings and the exposed structural elements . These elements are much larger than a person, making the overall room feel spacious and a bit industrial.
The large, voluminous pendant lamps, while providing light, also contribute to this grand scale.

INTIMATE OR HUMAN-CENTRIC SCALE

The long dining table is designed for a group, creating a communal and inviting atmosphere at a human scale. It's a focal point for interaction.
The shelving unit in the background, with its bottles and smaller items, operates at a detail-oriented, human-reach scale.

HIERARCHICAL SCALE

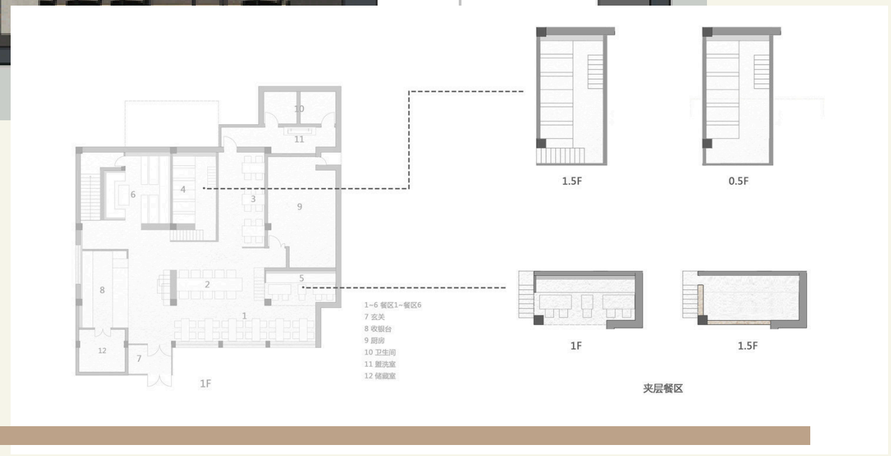
The large pendant lights are arguably the most prominent element, drawing the eye upwards and establishing a strong vertical scale.
The long table dominates the horizontal plane, grounding the space.

PRINCIPLES OF DESIGN

Balance

IS THE SIZE OF AN OBJECT IN RELATION TO ITS SURROUNDINGS.

ASYMMETRICAL BALANCE



PIT, MEZZANINE, LOG CABIN, AND PLANT SHELVES ARE UNEVENLY ARRANGED BUT VISUALLY STABLE.

- Materials: rough brick vs smooth wood.
- Spaces: open floor vs sunken pit, natural plants vs geometric mezzanine.

Contrast

IS THE USE OF OPPOSING ELEMENTS, LIKE LIGHT AND DARK OR LARGE AND SMALL, TO CREATE VISUAL INTEREST.

Unity / Harmony

REFER TO THE COHESIVE ARRANGEMENT OF ELEMENTS, MAKING THE DESIGN FEEL CONSISTENT AND VISUALLY PLEASING

- THE ORGANIC, ROUNDED SHAPES OF THE LIGHTS AND FINS PROVIDE A NATURAL, FLOWING CONTRAST TO THE STRICT, STRAIGHT LINES OF THE WALLS AND TABLES.

- CONSISTENT USE OF NATURAL MATERIALS, EARTHY TONES, AND GREENERY UNIFIES THE DESIGN.

Unity & Harmony

Consistent use of earth tones (browns, tans) and neutrals (white, gray).

This limited and warm palette is restful and prevents any one area from visually clashing with another.

Repetition of unique elements like the woven pendant lights and the vertical wavy wooden fins.

- Repeated use of three core textures:

- exposed brick,
-raw concrete,
-light natural wood.

The warm, rustic textures (brick/wood) soften and balance the cool, industrial hardness of the concrete, making the space inviting.

Strategic placement of potted plants and greenery throughout all areas.

Proportion / Scale

Adjusted to human comfort:

Pit depth
cozy communal zone.

Mezzanine height
intimate atmosphere.

Furniture
scaled for relaxation.

Scale Strategy Matrix: From Monumental to Intimate

The design uses contrasting scales to break up the large, industrial volume and create varied spatial experiences.

DESIGN SCALE (FOCUS)	ACHIEVING ELEMENT & IMPACT
GRAND SCALE	**Exposed Industrial Shell** The high, raw concrete ceiling and vast open floor plan establish the monumental backdrop, giving the entire space a dramatic, airy feel.
HUMAN SCALE	**Functional Furniture** The length and height of the communal wood tables and individual chairs define the immediate user experience, grounding the guest horizontally.
INTIMATE SCALE	**Visual Ceiling Lowering & Partitions** Oversized lighting pendants and the wave-like partition wall introduce elements closer to eye level, creating focused, cozy sub-spaces.

Movement

- Flow of circulation: enter → descend into pit → climb mezzanine → move through plant-divided zones.

- Visual movement from lines, repetition, and spatial layering.

Rhythm

- Repetition of shelves, beams, and partitions.
- Alternating patterns of plants and seating guide the eye.

RHYTHM

Exposed Brick Walls

Progression Vertical/Height

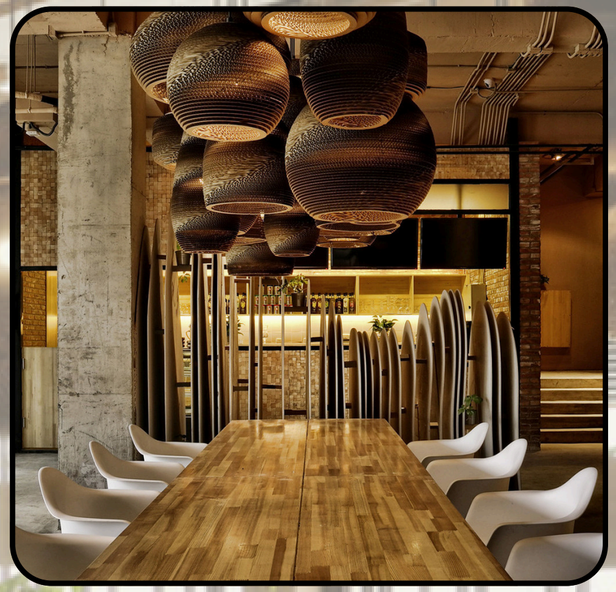
Vertical Dividers

Wood Walls/plane/ Staggered depth, natural tones

Element	Repetition (Pattern)	Progression (Variation)
Exposed Bricks	Repetition (Pattern)	Textured (rough/thrusting)
Consistent texture	Evaluating color tones	Varying sinc/tones
Vertical Frames	Parallel sizes	Varying light intensity
Changing light intensity	Staged depth	Staggered depth

Variety

Variety of seating:
open communal, private
log cabin, mezzanine.



Variety of textures:
brick, wood, greenery.

Emphasis

- Sunken pit as the centerpiece.

- Mezzanine and log cabin create strong points of interest.

CASE STUDY SUMMARY

Design Outcomes

- Smart use of height → sunken pit + mezzanine.
- Variety of spaces → open, semi-private, and intimate.
- Blend of natural (plants, wood) and geometric (pit, mezzanine).

Lesson Learned

- Constraints can inspire creativity.
- Natural elements improve comfort.
- Balance of elements and principles makes design effective.

CONCLUSION

Key Takeaways

- Shan Café shows how simple ideas can solve big challenges.
- A balance of openness, coziness, and nature creates identity.
- Creative use of space limitations can transform constraints into unique design opportunities.

Sham Café

THANK YOU

REFERENCES FROM:

WWW.ARCHDAILY.COM